

Indigo Plantations

Indigo is a plant whose leaves can be processed to produce a deep blue dye. For centuries, the dye was valued for colouring textiles, and European demand for indigo increased as textile production expanded. In colonial India, indigo became an important commercial crop because European planters could profit from selling the dye in international markets.

Under colonial rule, many indigo planters persuaded or pressured Indian peasants to cultivate indigo instead of food crops. In the Bengal region, peasants were often required to grow indigo on part of their land under arrangements that favoured the planters. Indigo could reduce the fertility of the soil and was less profitable for cultivators than crops grown for their own needs. As a result, many peasants became increasingly dissatisfied with the system.

This dissatisfaction contributed to the Indigo Revolt of 1859–60 in Bengal. Many cultivators refused to sow indigo and resisted the demands of European planters. The movement drew attention to the harsh conditions faced by peasants and led to official investigations. The Indigo Commission examined the complaints and concluded that peasants should not be forced to grow indigo. The revolt therefore became an important example of resistance to exploitative plantation practices in colonial India.